

Studying for boba: does this model work anywhere else?

Mr. Tapioca · Melchi Goldfarb, Cornell · put together after our call, August 2026

THE MODEL IN THREE LINES

- Students study with their distracting apps blocked while a virtual boba fills up. A big drink is about six hours of real focus, spread over days.
- Finishing a drink earns something at a partner shop. In person only, the shop picks the reward, joining costs nothing.
- The reward matters because it was hard to earn, and the shop only gives something up when a student is standing at the register.

WHERE EARN-A-REAL-REWARD-FOR-BEHAVIOR ALREADY WORKS

- **Pocket Points** (Chico State, 2014). Students earned points for keeping phones locked in class, spent them at shops near campus. Grew to 200+ campuses and around 1,200 small businesses. It later went quiet. My read: locking your phone in class is a cheap behavior, so the points stopped feeling earned. Six hours of studying is not cheap.
- **Sweatcoin** (2016). Steps become coins spent with 600+ brand partners. Over 150 million registered users. Verified behavior converts into merchant-funded rewards at scale.
- **ClassPass**. Pooled gyms' empty slots into one network. Studios accepted discounted access because the customers were ones they were never getting on their own. Acquired by Mindbody in 2021.
- **DietBet / HealthyWage**. People put real money on weight-loss goals and get paid for hitting them. Tens of millions paid out. Stakes change behavior.
- **Bank of America, Keep the Change** (2005). Every purchase rounds up into savings. The behavior-reward loop is mainstream enough that a bank built it.
- **Forest**. Tens of millions of people already pay for a gamified focus timer, with real trees planted as the real-world outcome. The study-timer half of this is a proven product on its own.

BOBA SPECIFICALLY

- The chains already run loyalty apps. Kung Fu Tea gives a "bubble" per \$2 spent, redeemable for free drinks. So rewards demonstrably move boba customers.
- Independent shops have nothing like it, and nobody anywhere ties boba rewards to verified study time. That is the open space.

THE SHOP MATH (WHAT I TOOK FROM OUR CALL)

- A percent discount can be half a shop's profit on a drink, so the design has to guarantee the customer is new:
- **First-visit trigger**. The big reward only fires the first time a student ever redeems at that shop. The app knows. Structurally 100% new business.
- **In-kind rewards**. A free topping or size upgrade costs the shop 20–40 cents of goods and feels like a dollar. The shop picks it.
- **Off-peak windows**. The shop can limit redemptions to slow hours, when the marginal cost of a drink is close to zero.
- **Capped pilot**. Thirty redemptions max in month one, so the worst case is about \$12 in toppings, and the shop gets a simple report: how many redemptions, how many first-time visitors.

This is the sheet I'd eventually adapt for shop owners. Be honest, what's wrong with it?

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